

Persuasive Messages Prompt #3:

Dress for Success: Persuasive Request

You work as a marketing co-op in the office of Community Relations and Marketing at SDSU. This office promotes and oversees all university events offered in partnership with non-profit organizations. One such event is the yearly donation drive on behalf of Dress for Success, a national organization with a chapter San Diego. This organization helps disadvantaged women enter the workplace and stay there. An important part of achieving this goal is collecting business-appropriate clothing for women to wear on job interviews. They also get a week's worth of working clothes when they are hired. (You can learn more about the organization at www.dressforsuccess.org.)

Your job is to write a one page persuasive message to the SDSU university community—faculty, staff—that asks for donations of new or nearly new suits (pants or skirts), blouses, shoes, and certain accessories. The message will be formatted, converted to HTML and appear as a separate web page on SDSU's Campus Connection website in early March.

Let readers know when and where they can drop off their donations. Inform them that all items should be clean and stylish, and they should be turned in on hangers or in boxes. Tell them that volunteers will be on hand at the collection sites next week during certain hours to accept the donations and give receipts for them. The volunteers will also be happy to accept donations in the form of checks or cash, but if people want to donate via credit card or PayPal, they must do so via the Dress for Success website. Your purpose here is to convince them, persuade them, to donate clothes.

Guidelines and details

As you draft the message, make sure you

- Know your readers: their motivations, education level, interests etc.
- Choose an appropriate combination of strategies that will best appeal to that audience
- Articulate the benefits that will win over the members of the university community
- Build your case using research about Dress for Success taken from the website above; make sure you know as much as you can about Dress for Success before you begin writing*
- Create an opening using that appeal that gains the reader's attention
- Make sure that community knows exactly what you want them to do
- Keep your request to one page, and avoid using the first-person pronoun ("I").

Resources

Review the "General Advice about Persuasion" section beginning on page 158 first, then focus on the "Persuasive Requests" section beginning on page 160, including all sample messages presented and discussed in that section. If you choose this prompt, you might pay particular attention to the "common-ground persuasion technique" in that section.

Contact Information

Title this message Persuasive Request on Behalf of Dress For Success, San Diego to the SDSU University Community, followed by your name.

* You do not need to cite the information about Dress for Success in your message.